

Title: How to Recognize and Respond to a Medical Emergency [Article]

Excerpt: Recognizing signs of a medical emergency is the first crucial step in providing efficient and effective care. This article details essential steps to both spotting and responding to a medical emergency, including calling 911, staying calm, and performing CPR.

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Quick—your best friend is having a heart attack and is unresponsive. **What should you do?** In a medical emergency, recognizing and responding immediately could save lives in a matter of minutes. It's key to understand the signs of a medical emergency and what you can do to save your own life or someone else's.

First, **what is a medical emergency?** According to the [Cleveland Clinic](#), a medical emergency is an illness or event that needs professional medical care as soon as possible. The symptoms are typically severe enough to result in serious impairment of bodily organs or parts, bodily functions, or to make a person a danger to themselves or others. This could look like bleeding that won't stop, losing a limb, head or spine injuries, sudden severe pain anywhere in the body, seizures, or becoming unconscious. All of these are classified as medical emergencies and require immediate attention by a medical professional, but you should still seek help if you're unsure.

How do you seek help? First, ensure that you are safe or in a safe place. Take a deep breath. Then, call 911 or ask someone to call emergency services for you. Stay calm and provide the operator with the exact details— your location, what the medical emergency is, and what happened— and follow the operator's instructions. Don't hang up the call unless they tell you to. You can also drive the person experiencing the medical emergency to the nearest hospital, unless you are experiencing the emergency yourself. However, it's generally advised against because medical responders can begin treatment immediately upon arrival, which is often faster than driving yourself.

Finally, after calling 911 or while 911 is being called, perform CPR (cardiopulmonary resuscitation) if necessary. Do not attempt this if it's unsafe to be in close proximity to the

person experiencing the medical emergency or if you don't know the proper technique. You can also place the person experiencing the emergency in the recovery position if they are unconscious and it is safe. According to the [American Red Cross](#), you should place them on their left side, with one arm up so they can lay their head on that arm. This helps keep the airways clear of blood, vomit, or any other fluid in the airway. Take the other hand and place it against their face, as if they're sleeping on a pillow. Bend one or both of their knees up to stabilize them. This allows you to monitor their airway and any changes that may occur. However, be very wary of any neck, head, or back injuries that the person may have, and don't perform these unless absolutely necessary. Wait patiently for the first responders to arrive. In a medical emergency, reacting quickly makes all the difference and can help save lives. Recognising the signs of an emergency and understanding how to respond to it is incredibly helpful in the case that you or someone around you is in danger. Remain calm, and when you aren't sure, call 911.